
**MY NOTES: CONCERNS AND RECOMMENDATIONS ABOUT AI
BY ORGANIZED LABOR, WITH SOME BACKGROUND RESOURCES**

To help us plan a public meeting that a team in which I am a member might sponsor, I organized notes from my reading and viewing of some concerns and recommendations from organized labor about the implementation of artificial intelligence (AI) in the workplace. I did not seek documents and videos widely, deeply, or comprehensively. Rather, I performed a quick-and-dirty tour and summary of resources I was able to read and view over the weekend. My aim was to offer some grist to grind in our discussions.

Concerns

Recent publications and policy statements from labor organizations, including some cited in the brief bibliography I include with this document, reveal recurring concerns regarding the introduction of AI into workplaces. Across these sources, unions do not typically oppose technological innovation per se; rather, they express concern about the conditions under which AI is deployed and the ultimate beneficiaries of its implementation. A central issue is job displacement and work reorganization. Unions worry that AI may eliminate positions in clerical, manufacturing, logistics, and even creative sectors, or restructure jobs into narrower, deskilled roles subject to intensified monitoring. Even when AI does not eliminate employment outright, it may fragment tasks and accelerate work pace in ways that reduce job quality.

Another widely shared concern involves algorithmic management and workplace surveillance. AI systems increasingly assign tasks, monitor productivity, evaluate performance, and in some cases trigger disciplinary action. Labor organizations argue that such systems can erode due process protections, heighten stress, and concentrate managerial authority in opaque digital systems. Relatedly, unions emphasize the “black box” nature of many AI tools: workers often do not know what data are being collected, how decisions are made, or how to challenge automated determinations. Consequently, unions frequently call for transparency requirements, explainability standards, and independent auditing mechanisms to ensure fairness and accountability.

Unions also raise concerns about the erosion of collective bargaining power. AI technologies are sometimes introduced unilaterally, without negotiation over their effects on wages, scheduling, staffing, or evaluation systems. Labor organizations increasingly argue that AI implementation should be treated as a mandatory subject of bargaining, encompassing protections against displacement, negotiated limits on surveillance, and joint oversight structures. Closely related is the issue of distribution: unions question whether productivity gains from AI will accrue primarily to executives and shareholders while workers experience stagnant wages or job insecurity. Many advocate for mechanisms that share gains more equitably, such as profit-sharing arrangements, stronger public workforce investment, and employer-funded retraining initiatives.

Last, unions consistently highlight risks of bias and discrimination embedded in AI systems used for hiring, scheduling, or evaluation. Because algorithmic systems are trained on historical data, they may reproduce racial, gender, or disability-based inequities. Labor organizations therefore call for civil rights compliance, anti-discrimination audits, and worker participation in system design and governance.

Taken together, these concerns reflect a broader pattern: unions tend to view AI not as an inevitable technological force but as a site of institutional choice and power negotiation. Their perspective centers on ensuring that AI is governed democratically, implemented transparently, and structured to enhance—rather than undermine—job quality, fairness, and worker voice.

The Path Forward

Recent publications and policy initiatives from labor organizations sought to outline a coherent set of recommended responses to the growing use of AI in the workplace. Although unions differ across sectors and national contexts, their proposals converge around a central objective: ensuring that AI is governed in ways that enhance job quality, protect worker rights, and distribute productivity gains equitably.

A primary recommended response is to embed AI deployment within collective bargaining frameworks. Unions argue that the introduction of AI systems—especially those affecting hiring, evaluation, scheduling, and discipline—should be treated as a mandatory subject of bargaining. This approach would require employers to negotiate over how AI tools are implemented, what data are collected, and how automated decisions affect wages, staffing, and working conditions. By incorporating AI governance into collective agreements, unions seek to prevent unilateral managerial control and to ensure that workers retain meaningful voice over technological change.

Closely related is the call for transparency and accountability mechanisms. Unions advocate for legal and contractual requirements that make algorithmic systems explainable and auditable. Recommended measures include granting workers access to information about how AI systems evaluate performance, establishing independent audits to detect bias or discrimination, and creating clear procedures for challenging automated decisions. These safeguards are designed to preserve due process rights and prevent the entrenchment of opaque “black box” systems that shield managerial decisions from scrutiny.

Unions also recommend policies to safeguard job quality and mitigate displacement risks. Rather than solely focusing on preventing automation, labor organizations often emphasize shaping its consequences. Proposed responses include advance notice requirements before technological changes, negotiated limits on surveillance, job security provisions, and just transition frameworks for workers whose roles are substantially altered or eliminated. Many unions advocate for employer-funded retraining programs and public investment in workforce development to ensure that workers can adapt to new technological demands without bearing disproportionate costs.

Another core recommendation concerns the distribution of AI-generated productivity gains. Unions argue that efficiency improvements should translate into higher wages, reduced working hours, improved benefits, or profit-sharing arrangements rather than solely increasing shareholder returns. In this view, AI governance is inseparable from broader questions of economic inequality and social justice. By advocating mechanisms that link productivity to worker compensation, unions seek to ensure that technological progress supports broadly shared prosperity.

Finally, labor organizations frequently call for stronger public regulation of AI systems. Recommended policy responses include enforceable standards on data protection, anti-discrimination safeguards, limitations on invasive workplace surveillance, and frameworks for worker participation in technology governance. Some unions also support tripartite models—bringing together labor, employers, and government—to establish national guidelines for responsible AI deployment. These regulatory approaches reflect the belief that collective bargaining alone may be insufficient in highly digitized and globally integrated labor markets.

Taken together, the responses offered by unions reflect a strategic shift from resisting technology to reshaping its governance. AI is treated not as an inevitable or purely technical development but as a site of institutional choice and political negotiation. Through collective bargaining, transparency requirements, training investments, equitable distribution mechanisms, and public regulation, unions aim to align AI innovation with democratic values, worker dignity, and long-term economic stability.

Some Recent Resources

Written

AFL-CIO. (2025, October 15). *AFL-CIO launches ‘Workers First Initiative on AI’ to put American workers at the future of artificial intelligence.*

<https://aflcio.org/press/releases/afl-cio-launches-workers-first-initiative-ai-put-american-workers-future-artificial>

A press release from the AFL-CIO outlining its “Workers First Initiative on AI,” a comprehensive vision for worker-centered AI policy. The initiative reflects unions’ perceptions that workers should benefit from AI while protecting job quality, safety, and worker voice in AI design and regulation.

American Progress. (2024, May 16). *Unions give workers a voice over how AI affects their jobs.* <https://www.americanprogress.org/article/unions-give-workers-a-voice-over-how-ai-affects-their-jobs>

An analysis of how unions use collective bargaining to negotiate protections around AI, including limits on job elimination and surveillance, showing how unions understand AI as both a tool and a risk that must be shaped through worker voice and bargaining power.

Cornell University ILR School. (2025, May 2). *Webinar: AI and the future for workers: Labor union responses to artificial intelligence.*

<https://www.ilr.cornell.edu/carow/post/webinar-ai-and-future-workers>

An academic-union webinar exploring how unions (e.g., AFL-CIO Technology Institute, CWA, UNI Global Union) are responding to AI’s workplace impacts through collective bargaining, organizing, and policy coalitions, showing union perspectives on both challenges and strategic responses.

Equal Times. (2024). *Trade union strategies on artificial intelligence and collective bargaining on algorithms.* <https://www.equaltimes.org/trade-union-strategies-on>

An article detailing union strategies, including the AFL-CIO’s partnership with Microsoft to include worker input in AI design, collective bargaining commitments to negotiate AI implications, and efforts to shape public policy and contract language reflecting union perceptions of AI’s impact.

International Trade Union Confederation. (2025, October 17). *Artificial intelligence: Workers’ unions must shape deployment and regulation.*

<https://www.ituc-csi.org/Artificial-Intelligence-Workers-unions-must-shape-deployment-and-regulation>

A report by the International Trade Union Confederation emphasizing that trade unions must be central to how AI is deployed and regulated. It discusses risks such as job fragmentation, algorithmic management, and labor rights erosion—and highlights union-led collective agreements and organizing efforts addressing AI impacts.

Jyotishi, S. (2025, July 30). *Why AI researchers need to hear more from workers and unions*. <https://www.techpolicy.press/why-ai-researchers-need-to-hear-more-from-workers-and-unions/>

Policymakers should task government agencies that fund this work to study, pilot, and scale approaches that foster partnerships between the labor sector and R&D leaders in academia, industry, and technology-based economic development. Unions and workers aren't resisting the fourth industrial revolution — they seek to help shape it. Recent moves to elevate worker voice around AI in labor contracts won by the Writers Guild of America and the Communication Workers of America illustrate what's possible and set a precedent for other unions to follow.

Khan, M., & Feng, K. (2025, September 18). *A first look at labor's AI values: An analysis of recent statements about technology by unions and other worker organizations*. UC Berkeley Labor Center. <https://laborcenter.berkeley.edu/a-first-look-at-labors-ai-values/>

A report analyzing official statements and principles from multiple unions and worker organizations, identifying common values such as fairness, transparency, worker participation, and precaution in AI deployment—showing how unions conceptualize ethical AI that aligns with worker interests.

Kresge, L. (2025). *Negotiating tech: An inventory of U.S. union contract provisions for the digital age*. UC Berkeley Labor Center. <https://laborcenter.berkeley.edu/negotiating-tech/>

Negotiating Tech is an online searchable inventory developed by the UC Berkeley Labor Center's Technology and Work Program that compiles and analyzes how labor unions in the United States have addressed workplace technologies through collective bargaining. Drawing from over 500 collective bargaining agreements—with more than 175 containing relevant clauses—the resource categorizes contract language into areas such as technology definitions, foundational rights (e.g., advance notice, information disclosure, bargaining rights), employer commitments (e.g., job security, retraining), governance of tech applications (e.g., monitoring systems), worker participation mechanisms (e.g., joint committees), and other provisions related to data rights and remote work. Rather than prescribing model language, the inventory illustrates the diverse strategies unions have used to secure protections, negotiate implementation conditions, and shape technology adoption and oversight in the digital workplace.

It serves as a practical tool for union negotiators, researchers, and policymakers interested in understanding and advancing labor's role in governing workplace technologies.

Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development. (2023). *Social dialogue and collective bargaining in the age of artificial intelligence* (OECD Employment Outlook). https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/2023/07/oecd-employment-outlook-2023_904bcef3/full-report/social-dialogue-and-collective-bargaining-in-the-age-of-artificial-intelligence_5828691a.html

An OECD report discussing union and employer perspectives on AI and digital technologies. It highlights ethical concerns raised by unions (e.g., human rights and discrimination risks) and how these perceptions differ from employer priorities, offering broader socio-economic context.

Trade Union Congress (TUC). (2023). *A snapshot of workers in Wales' understanding and experience of AI*. <https://www.tuc.org.uk/research-analysis/reports/snapshot-workers-wales-understanding-and-experience-ai>

A qualitative report focusing on how trade unionists in Wales understand and engage with AI in their workplaces. It highlights widespread awareness of AI impacts, shared concerns about fairness and job effects, and the need for stronger tools and resources to empower union engagement with AI issues.

<https://www.techpolicy.press/why-ai-researchers-need-to-hear-more-from-workers-and-unions/>

Video

AI could wipe out the working class | Sen. Bernie Sanders.

<https://youtu.be/dthbi4lzO58?si=1dz6oySXEqLmj7BM>

The artificial intelligence and robotics being developed by multi-billionaires will allow corporate America to wipe out tens of millions of decent-paying jobs, cut labor costs and boost profits. What happens to working class people who can't find jobs because they don't exist?

AI vs. teacher unions: Has the replacement battle begun?

<https://youtu.be/n5ZW45Vz1yU?si=ITG8gc1OgAz4Yp05>

The growing tension between teaching unions and government plans to integrate AI into UK schools.

America's stone age ports: How unions block progress.

<https://youtu.be/Z1pnLPcnyLc?si=svVbHbwgEKlNlrN5>

At some ports, remarkable machines now move shipments with no humans in sight. That innovation upsets unions. International Longshoreman's Association president Harold Daggett says they'll soon strike if automation isn't completely banned.

House hearing on AI and workplace safety. <https://youtu.be/1kmOJXvaAYs?si=-cpsbnVNOjKauQw->

House Committee on Education and the Workforce, Subcommittee on Workforce Protections hearing entitled, "Building an AI-Ready America: Safer Workplaces Through Smarter Technology."

Is AI going to take nursing jobs?

<https://youtu.be/odlLaZwMrns?si=Xd6eVNwl553YN5Zz>

AI is replacing jobs left and right, but nursing is still one of the safest careers in 2025. In this video, the data are broken down on which healthcare roles are at risk, why nursing isn't one of them, and how to stay ahead as AI grows in hospitals.

Negotiating A.I. contracts - How unions can advance A.I. protections across sectors. <https://youtu.be/FsPLRP2YA7Y?si=QEsDurqXWFSlVOuW>

Negotiators from entertainment industry unions discuss how they positioned and bargained to win critical control over A.I. use in their contracts.

Teamsters President Sean O'Brien on AI, unions, and protecting workers' rights

<https://youtu.be/-oLISA9QgdE?si=9oNIUtddK9hdMvv7>

In this interview, Teamsters President Sean O'Brien joins Tucker Carlson to discuss the future of work amidst the rise of AI and automation. They explore working people's real fears about job security and the role unions play in safeguarding workers' rights in an increasingly automated world. O'Brien outlines how unions, like the Teamsters, are fighting to ensure that workers are not left behind as technology evolves.

The role of unions in the age of artificial intelligence.

<https://youtu.be/NHHeaMZhFWk?si=A1U9C3IQrctMP96O>

A professor of law explores the legal considerations for unions in negotiating AI governance frameworks with employers. Discussed is the necessity for unions to become proactive players in shaping AI's implementation in the workplace, particularly regarding worker safety, discrimination, and data privacy. The conversation delves into the evolving role of unions in the age of AI, advocating for their involvement in the governance and ethical frameworks surrounding AI technology to ensure fair treatment of workers.